

STAX Lab Follow-Up Email

Follow-up on the 2022 school lunch grant scoring change

From: The Hon. Dr. Sir Jensen Ahokovi, PhD, MA, BA. <jensen@stax.example>
To: STAX Predoc Team <predocs@stax.example>
Date: Thursday, March 14, 2024 at 3:42 PM
Attach: student_health_wellbeing_survey_extract.csv

Hi team,

Thanks for putting together the school-year panel and the notes. This is very helpful, and I think it may be enough for a more serious specification pass.

One more thing: I confirmed that the state changed the modernization grant scoring in 2022. After the change, applications tied to scratch-cooking equipment, cold storage, and healthier serving-line infrastructure appear to have received a clearer priority. That may give us a useful timing change to explore, though I do not want to assume it is a clean policy break without checking the panel.

I also attached a school-year survey extract with aggregate student health and wellbeing measures. Please merge it carefully before using those variables. If the scoring change mattered in practice, I would expect to see something like more schools receiving grants, larger grant amounts, or improvements in lunch participation, healthy-meal scores, and aggregate student health or wellbeing measures after 2022.

Please be cautious with the wellbeing and mental-health-related measures. A referral rate could reflect need, detection, service access, or reporting practice, so treat those checks as exploratory survey signals rather than proof of a mental-health effect.

Could you use your judgment to propose the best feasible comparisons and code them up? I would like to see which specifications are only descriptive, which are exploratory, and whether anything like a fixed-effects, event-study, or dose-response check is credible enough to inspect.

I mostly want to know whether there is anything promising here, what the estimates look like under those specifications, and what we would need to check before taking any result seriously.

Thanks,

The Hon. Dr. Sir Jensen Ahokovi, PhD, MA, BA.